And third, but most of all, his unconventionality and willingness to stand up, fight for, and even fail, for what he considered good for people and country. With no political godfather before he joined his junior school mate, Rajiv Gandhi, when he became prime minister by chance (the original 'accidental PM'), he upheld Tagore's exhortation to walk alone: '*ekla chalo re*'.

His loyalty to his political mentor, his debt and devotion to his highly accomplished family that stood by him through thick and thin, and his searing sense of failure at being unable to close many lofty initiatives that he threw his heart and soul into, come out poignantly through this book. I can think of no more instructive ringside lessons in mainstream Indian politics for aspiring young politicians fired by idealism than this.

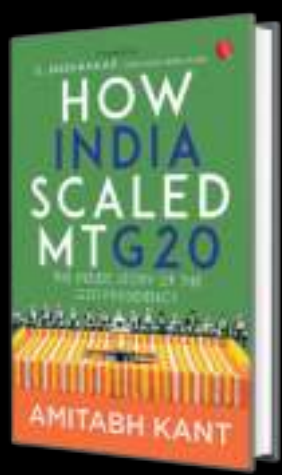
What stands out is his total commitment to secularism, his stubborn advocacy of better India-Pakistan relations, his suspicion of the liberalisation programme post 1991 and his compelling conviction that secularism and socialism had to go hand in hand to counter the juggernaut of Hindutva communalism, a caution that the Congress party failed to grasp.

What stands out is *MANI'S* commitment to secularism, and his conviction that socialism and secularism must work together

Equally compelling are the numerous controversies that he inevitably triggered, his media presence and role as a public intellectual; his scathing intolerance of those he considered unworthy, and his irrepressible tongue that often got him into trouble; his strangely formal relationship with 'the family', and his feeling of devastation at being cast into political oblivion seemingly for off-the-cuff statements that were deliberately distorted by his opponents. Mani tries to set the record straight from his point of view on many of these.

Curiously, for an association that he regards as one that gave him the most satisfaction, Mani devotes one of his briefest (and flattest) chapters to his tenure as minister for DONER (Development of North Eastern Region). Tasked by PM Manmohan Singh to draw up a 'Vision Document' for the Northeast, the chapter is mostly a summary of the document and its follow-up. It was an ambitious agenda that he pursued with characteristic gusto, reinvigorating the North-Eastern Council (NEC), holding meeting after sectoral meeting and organising outreach events to canvass their findings to society at large. It offers a tantalising glimpse into a model of development for the Northeast that is not based on the extractive and plantation industries in force since colonial (and into present) times. Sadly, before he could embark on its implementation, Mani lost the 2009 election and entered a period of political wilderness from which he never really recovered. ■

–Gautam Mukhopadhaya



HOW INDIA SCALED MT G20: THE INSIDE STORY OF THE G20 PRESIDENCY
by Amitabh Kant
RUPA
₹595; 256 pages

G7 and reflect instead the expectations and concerns of the Global South, including a Green Development Pact. India also wanted to showcase its remarkable success in creating digital public infrastructure as an inclusive development tool for developing countries.

How India succeeded in producing a consensus document despite acute differences on the Ukraine issue is the most engrossing part of the book. With repeatedly unsuccessful attempts to find agreed language on the Ukraine conflict, with Russia and China hardening their positions post-Bali and the western group unwilling to yield on its position, India's decision to cut the knot, draft its own compromise text and present it to the G20 members on a "take it or leave it basis" under Modi's direction proved a tour de force.

Success is heady. Kant's claims sound a bit hyperbolic when he says that the G20 presidency showed that "India could manage international engagements on a scale that surpassed mere perfection", or that his book "chronicles the pivotal role India played in reshaping global governance", or, indeed, that our G20 presidency was comparable to the lasting impact on the global landscape such as that of Kennedy's firm stand on the Cuban Missile Crisis or Deng's sweeping economic reforms in China. This reflects Kant's characteristic exuberance, which is infectious. But Kant (and others) did not anticipate Trumpian disruptions.

Altogether a well written and readable book. ■

–Kanwal Sibal